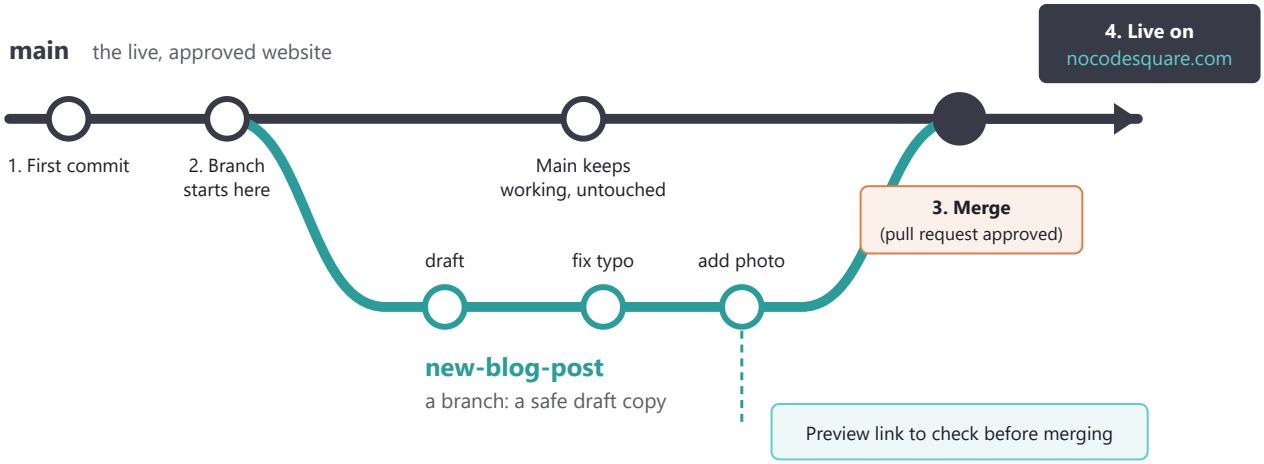
NOCODESQUARE · A 2-PAGE GUIDE

How GitHub branches *work.*

What "main" means, what other branches are for, and how a change gets from an idea to nocodesquare.com.

The idea in one picture

Think of **main** as the **approved, live version** of the website, like the printed menu on a restaurant table. A **branch** is a **draft copy** in the kitchen: you can test a new dish there without changing the menu customers see. When the dish is good, it goes onto the menu.



Each circle is a **commit**: a saved snapshot of the code with a note saying what changed.

Your understanding, checked

You said: *"we work on a branch first, and when we're done we push it to main and the site updates."* That's **almost exactly right**. One word needs fixing:

> **Push ≠ merge. Push** means *upload*: sending saved work from a computer to GitHub. You push a *branch* to GitHub. **Merge** means *combine*: folding the branch's changes into main. So the flow is: work on a branch → **push** the branch → **merge** it into main → the site updates.

Why bother with branches?

1. **Main never breaks.** Half-finished work lives on a branch, so the live site always works.
2. **You can look before it goes live.** Each branch gets its own preview link to check on your phone.
3. **Several things can happen at once.** A blog post and a merch price change can each be on their own branch.
4. **Easy to cancel.** Don't like it? Delete the branch. Main is untouched.

The words you'll hear

Repository (repo)	The project folder on GitHub, with its full history. Ours: `nocodesquare-cloud/Nocodesquare-site`.
Commit	A saved snapshot plus a short note ("Add Lauren Jude story"). You can always go back to any commit.
Branch	A separate line of commits: a draft copy where changes are made safely.
main	The default branch. By agreement it is the **approved, live** version. Cloudflare publishes whatever is on main.
Push	Upload commits from a computer to GitHub.
Pull	Download the latest commits from GitHub to a computer.
Pull request (PR)	A request on GitHub that says "please merge this branch into main". It shows exactly what changed, so someone can review it first.
Merge	Combine a branch into main. After merging, the branch can be deleted.
Conflict	When two branches changed the same line differently, someone must choose which version wins. Rare if branches stay small.

How it will work for Nocodesquare

1. **A change starts on a branch**, for example `lauren-story` or `new-merch-prices`.
2. **The branch is pushed to GitHub.** Cloudflare builds a **preview link** for it automatically.
3. **You open the preview** and check it. Ask for changes if needed; they go onto the same branch.
4. **When you're happy, the pull request is merged into main.**
5. **Cloudflare sees main changed and publishes it** to nocodesquare.com in about a minute.

The admin dashboard follows the same idea. When you write a blog post there, it can be saved as a draft (a branch), previewed, then published (merged into main).

> **Where we are today.** The repo has one branch, **main**, with one commit: the whole website as it is now. We pushed straight to main because there was nothing live to protect yet. Once nocodesquare.com is live, changes go through branches and previews first.

Three rules worth keeping

1. **Main must always work.** Never merge something you haven't looked at.
2. **One branch, one job.** Small branches are easy to review and rarely conflict.
3. **Name branches by what they do**: `blog-voice-ai`, not `test2`.
